Openhearted, Not Unguarded

Quick Reference

A Resilience Playbook for Recovery Communities

Build a web of support, not a circle of perfect people. Get to know people in more than one circle. Then trouble in one relationship doesn't leave you with nowhere to turn.

These are practices, not steps. Use what fits the situation. The aim is to stay open to connection while caring for yourself and others.

A. Build connections

Start small and keep showing up. Say hello, listen, take part, ask questions, and follow up or check in later. Be imperfect. Let trust grow over time. Close friends and casual connections both matter.

Share only what you choose. You can talk about what you're going through without names or private details about your life. You don't have to share everything with anyone.

Give and receive. Ask for what you need. Offer what you can. Let others help you, too. You don't have to earn care by being useful.

Make room for repair. When contact is safe and welcome, listen, own your part, and agree on what needs to change. Follow through. Being friendly again doesn't always mean the problem is fixed. Repair doesn't require staying in the relationship. You can tend to your own healing even when you can't resolve things together. People aren't replaceable; other connections give us somewhere to turn when one relationship becomes difficult.

B. Practice discernment

Pause and notice what is happening.

Feeling uneasy doesn't always mean danger. Feeling calm or pleased doesn't prove things are fine. Your feelings are real, but they aren't facts.

Ask: **What happened? What am I assuming? What do I need?**

Use these questions when they help:

Freedom: Can I say no, slow down, or change my mind? Do I give others that same room?

Stakes: What might I risk by saying no? What might they feel they risk by disappointing me?

Drives: Is a need for attention or praise changing what I accept or do? Am I treating their response as something they owe me?

Influence: How is this connection shaping what I want? What am I leading the other person to expect?

Leave room to learn. Your ideas about someone else's feelings may be wrong. A welcome response doesn't prove that you're treating them with care. Look at the effects over time. You don't have to analyze every interaction or settle every doubt.

C. Respect autonomy

Make room for your choices and other people's choices.

You can ask, decline, change your mind, or leave. Others can too. Your needs matter, but one person may not meet them. Seek other support rather than press for a different answer.

Opening up isn't an invitation to romantic or sexual attention. Giving help doesn't buy private information, intimacy, or continued contact. You don't owe those things in return for help.

Keep freely made commitments, or say what needs to change. You don't have to stay in an unsafe interaction to honor an agreement.

Use your influence with care. More influence calls for more care, not more control. Be clear about what you want and can offer. State your limits without using someone's need for your help to get your way. Give people time to decide and room for other relationships. Step back when your attention isn't wanted.

D. Seek support

You don't need proof before asking for help. Talk with a friend, sponsor, someone who helps run your meeting, or a professional. You can ask about how someone treats you, how you treat them, or something you've seen happen to others.

Choose the next step that fits. You might set a limit, take space, work through discomfort, try repair, or seek protection. You don't have to confront someone or try repair before getting help.

Describe behavior, not someone's character. Say what you saw or heard, what worries you, and what you don't know. When it fits, share what you noticed and listen to their view. Seek help, not an audience. Gossip can push people away from the community where they're trying to heal. Protect privacy, but don't hide harm.

You deserve support even if you missed the signs or found it hard to say no. You are not to blame for someone else's harmful behavior. If one person can't help, try someone else. Staying in recovery doesn't mean staying in a relationship or meeting that harms you.

We don't need perfect people or perfect certainty to build a resilient fellowship.

Everyone deserves a chance at recovery. Everyone deserves to feel safe seeking it.

More guidance: MA Safety Card

Help improve this guide: What helps? What is hard to understand or use? Feedback: amalgam-mustard4k@icloud.com

Read the comprehensive guide for more detail and examples

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